

*A Wind Blows Heavy*

I look through the transom with two coffees in hand. There's a pink in the clouds like peaches. We spin out the polished revolving door, and are emptied onto Pacific Ave.

Immediately, we hear pigeons flapping over taxis and the feet of thousands. The sidewalk is full of distractions. One, however, tickles my teeth.

“There’s always an ambulance.” I hand Estelle a coffee, black.

“Yeah, but look.” She points above a gaggle of frumpy tourists. They’re huddled in the middle of the sidewalk. She tilts my chin up.

“There isn’t always a breeze.” Estelle says. Her thumb splits my lips as she brings her hand down to mine. We walk. I let Estelle guide.

The peach sunlight spills through the Cherry trees. They match Estelle’s nails. Blossoms twirl from the sky. They land on the bricks below. Most get stepped on, turning into mush. Estelle laughs, pulling croissants out of her bag.

“Well, here’s to a new start.” She jabs a croissant towards me.

The siren comes up on us. I stop in place. At full pitch, I cover my ears. As I do this, Estelle places bread in my mouth. She stands there grinning at me. Her pastry is loose in hand until she drops it. She isn’t crying, but there are tears dropping.

I see the other cheek as the siren stretches away. In that space where compressed waves elongate into lower tones. My mouth falls all the way open. The croissant hits the ground, landing next to hers.

In the depth of the warble, as it drives away, I see a jump in her eyes. It quickly crashes, as fifty feet relative to us, St.Mary's bells begin to ring.

Ring.

As we round the corner, a pregnant woman glares. Her husband's eyes loiter.

“Let me get that off your wrist.” I move to help Estelle, but get lured in by that woman.

The lady turns after passing. I stare at her gaze as Estelle pulls off the laminated bracelet. It takes her a single gentle tug. The paper dangles in the wind as if by magic.

“You get used to it so quickly.” She whispers.

Ring

I think of her as last month. Catching her sitting on the edge of the roof. She was just swinging her feet in the dusk. These are those eyes, and now we’re here.

She releases. I snatch the bracelet midair, and put it in my dress pocket. Patting my leg to comfort it.

“Now who’s the crazy one.” Her giggle hollows with the bells.

Just as sound melds with silence, we arrive. There’s an iron sign welcoming all to Cobble Hill Park. We stop to take it in.

I point to the tulips, maples, daisies, and oaks. She’s staring at the families. Above us, several branches shake and spill their leaves. Still, she doesn’t look up.

“It’s their way of saying hello.” I elbow at her side, nodding. “That’s what my grandma used to say anyways.”

“Mine won’t talk to me.” Estelle says looking down.

“They’re just.” I grab her hand. “They have the best daughter, and they can’t even see it.”

She shakes her head as I force a laugh.

“Let’s try to make it to the water?” I point westward on our path. “The sun is just setting.”

We walk further in the park. She stops at the start of the ecliptic walking path. Her hair is a flame while silhouetting the sun. Estelle points. I look.

There is one open bench out of the many lining the sides. A group of teenagers giggle as we walk over. I try to scowl, but my eyes end up watering. They see this, and quietly go back to vaping. One of the girls yells at the rest of the group. We both sit.

A ferry blows its horn, holding the tone for ten seconds straight. Babies start to wake up and cry. Not one person looks towards the emanation as it clumsily climbs up from Atlantic Ave.

Another siren goes off, and an old man curses, slamming his book closed. He gets up and leaves. Only we watch him stomp away.

“I wonder how long it will take?” I ask Estelle

“I think that’s up to them.” She grabs my thigh.

Sure enough, blaring and all, the ambulance sits, and waits. No one pays it any mind.

“They.” She continues with her head down.

“Know it’s their fault.” I interrupt, lowering my head to meet hers. “I made sure of that.”

As if on cue, the wind blows heavy. It washes into a Maple tree. A colony of Sapsuckers sing as they sway. On the tail end, an explosion in the sky. White petals and green leaves spin to the ground. Our feet are adorned. She points as the corollas which break apart after being stepped on.

“It’s the same with my family.” I offer. “Really any dolls’, hon.”

She rests her head on my shoulder. Cautiously, as if testing to see if it’s hot. We both get goosebumps.

“Your skin is so soft,” I say, stroking her arm.

An old man sees this and walks up. He reminds me of my mother's father, short and stout. He doesn't say a word, but does move slowly. He tries to nonchalantly snap a photo on his Canon, but the flash goes off. To this I do jump.

"At least pay me first asshole" I start yelling.

The tourist walks away. The women in the park are staring. All the men are gorging on us like fermented fruit. Estelle tugs me back to the bench.

"Calm now Bestie." Estelle pets.

Before I can, a woman walks up, and asks us to leave. Another siren goes off. This time, instead of jumping in all brazen head, Estelle just rolls her eyes, and lights a cigarette. There's a blue in the sky like huckle berries.